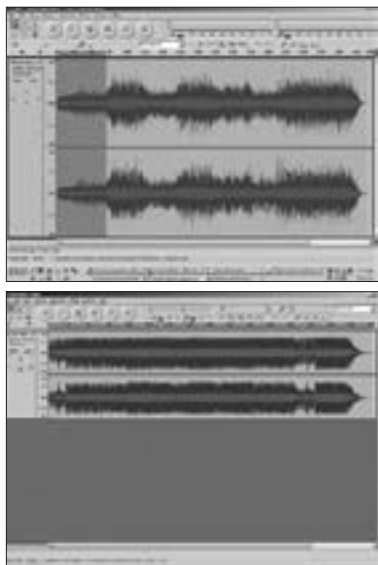


5.6 How Normalisation Works

When normalising a wave, the audio editor treats the output range of your sound-card as percentages—0% means total silence, and 100% is the maximum possible sound output before clipping (§5.7) occurs. You could normalise your audio to any percentage within this range, meaning that no part of the sound will cross that level. So normalising to 80% will ensure that even at its loudest, the sound output will never exceed 80% of the maximum. Rather than offer you percentages, some audio editors will ask you to set a normalisation using decibels. The unit in play here is dBFS—decibels Full Scale. The maximum (yes, maximum) value that you should set this to is 0dBFS.



The before and after pictures of a normalised waveform

In most cases, normalising to 100% (or 0dB) will do the trick, but you also need to consider whether the files will be used later for any other audio editing work. If so, you should normalise to about 95% (or -0.5dB) which should give you enough room to play around with more effects.

Let's now get to normalising a track using Audacity.

5.6.1 Normalising Using Audacity

First open Audacity, then choose File > Open, and select the song you want to normalise. You should now see a waveform as in the